

Leadership Communication Checklist

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Leadership Communication Checklist

A 15-item checklist for leaders communicating change, strategy, or difficult news — covering message clarity, audience needs, and channel selection. Includes the CLEAR message framework, an audience segmentation guide, and a channel selection matrix.

15 Checks

CLEAR Framework

Audience Guide

Channel Matrix

15

checks

3

dimensions

5

audience segments

10

channels rated

HOW TO USE

Work through the checklist before preparing any significant leadership communication. Use the CLEAR framework to build your message, the audience segmentation guide to tailor it, and the channel matrix to choose how to deliver it. A communication that passes all 15 checks will be significantly more effective than one that does not.

The 15-Item Checklist

MESSAGE CLARITY

- 01

☐

I can state the core message in one sentence.
If you cannot summarise what you need to communicate in a single sentence, you are not yet clear enough to communicate it to others. Write the sentence before you prepare anything else.
- 02

☐

I have separated what I know for certain from what is still uncertain.
Mixing fact and uncertainty in the same statement erodes trust. Say clearly: 'What I know is... What is still being decided is... What I cannot tell you yet is...'
- 03

☐

I have anticipated the three questions my audience is most likely to ask.
Your audience will always ask: What does this mean for me? Why now? What happens next? If you cannot answer these confidently, you are not ready to communicate.
- 04

☐

My message explains the why — not just the what.
People can accept almost any decision if they understand the reasoning behind it. A message without a 'why' invites speculation, and speculation is almost always worse than the truth.

05 ☐ **I have removed jargon, acronyms, and insider language that non-specialists will not understand.**

Read your message as if you are a frontline team member receiving it, not as the leader who wrote it. Every piece of unexplained jargon is a signal that the communication is designed for the sender's convenience, not the audience's understanding.

AUDIENCE NEEDS

06 ☐ **I have identified every group who needs to hear this message — including those indirectly affected.**

Direct recipients are easy to identify. Think about who else will be affected: adjacent teams, partners, customers, suppliers. Hearing significant news from someone other than you damages the relationship.

07 ☐ **I have tailored the level of detail and technical content for each audience segment.**

The same message delivered at the same level of detail to every audience will be too much for some and too little for others. Segmentation is not about having different messages — it is about the same message at different depths.

08 ☐ **I have considered what each audience group stands to lose or gain, and addressed it explicitly.**

People who stand to lose something will not hear the rest of your message until their concern has been acknowledged. Name the loss before you explain the benefit.

09 ☐ **I have thought about the emotional state my audience is likely to be in when they receive this message.**

Timing matters as much as content. A team receiving difficult news on a Friday afternoon before a holiday weekend will process it differently than the same team on a Tuesday morning. Consider what state they will be in before you decide when to communicate.

10 ☐ **I have planned how I will create space for questions, concerns, and reactions — not just deliver the message.**

Communication is not transmission. It is only complete when the recipient has understood and had the opportunity to respond. Build in time for questions in every communication event, however large.

CHANNEL SELECTION

11 ☐ **I have matched the channel to the significance of the message.**

Significant news delivered via email signals that it is not that significant. A redundancy, a major restructure, or a serious performance concern belongs in a face-to-face conversation. Match the weight of the channel to the weight of the message.

12 ☐ **I have considered whether the message is better delivered by me directly or cascaded through managers.**

Cascade communication preserves local relationships and allows managers to contextualise the message for their teams. Direct communication from senior leadership signals importance and reduces rumour. Choose deliberately — do not default.

13 ☐ **I have thought about whether a written record of this communication is needed — for clarity, accountability, or legal reasons.**

Important commitments, changes to working arrangements, or anything with potential legal implications should be confirmed in writing — even if the initial conversation was verbal. This protects both the organisation and the individual.

14 ☐ **I have planned the sequence — who needs to know first, and in what order.**

Sequence failures are common and costly. If managers hear the same news as their teams, simultaneously, they lose credibility and authority. Senior leaders, then line managers, then teams — with enough time between each for managers to prepare.

15 ☐ **I have identified how I will know whether the message has been understood and received as intended.**

Sending is not communicating. Plan a feedback mechanism: a check-in call, a follow-up survey, manager feedback, or simply asking directly. Without this, you have no way of knowing whether the communication achieved its purpose.

The CLEAR Message Framework

Use this framework to build your message before choosing a channel or writing any content. Complete each section in writing — the discipline of writing forces clarity that thinking alone rarely produces.

C Core message

What is the single most important thing I need this audience to understand, believe, or do after receiving this communication?

Write it in one sentence. If you cannot, keep simplifying until you can. Everything else in the communication should serve this sentence.

L Loss and gain

What does this audience stand to lose or gain? Which concern is most likely to dominate their reaction?

Name the concern explicitly in your communication. Acknowledging what people stand to lose is not weakness — it is the prerequisite for them hearing anything else you say.

E Evidence and reason

What evidence, data, or reasoning explains why this decision was made or this change is happening?

People can accept almost any outcome if they understand the reasoning. Withholding the 'why' does not protect you — it creates speculation that is almost always worse.

A Action and next steps

What do I need people to do, think, or feel differently after receiving this message? What happens next, and by when?

Every communication should be clear about whether it requires action or is for information only. If action is needed, name it, own it, and date it.

R Response and feedback

How will I create space for questions and reactions? How will I know whether the message landed as intended?

Communication is only complete when the recipient has had the opportunity to respond. Plan the feedback loop before you communicate, not after.

Audience Segmentation Guide

Different audiences need different versions of the same message — not because the truth changes, but because what matters to them, and how much detail they need, is different. Use this guide to plan your communication for each group.

THE SEQUENCE RULE

Always communicate in order of who bears the most responsibility for implementing or explaining the change. Senior leaders first, then line managers, then directly affected employees, then indirectly affected employees, then external stakeholders. Never communicate externally before employees are informed.

AUDIENCE SEGMENT

Senior Leaders / Sponsors

WHAT THEY CARE ABOUT	WHAT TO INCLUDE	CHANNEL	TIMING
Strategic impact, budget, reputation, board implications	Headline decision and rationale. Financial and strategic impact. Risk. What they need to decide or approve.	One-to-one briefing or small leadership session before wider communication. Written summary to follow.	Before anyone else. Minimum 24 hours before cascade.

AUDIENCE SEGMENT

Line Managers

WHAT THEY CARE ABOUT	WHAT TO INCLUDE	CHANNEL	TIMING
How to lead their teams through the change. Questions they will be asked.	Full context and rationale. Talking points for team conversations. What they can and cannot share. Support available.	Briefing session with Q&A. Written manager guide. Follow-up line available.	After senior leaders. Before team communication. Allow time to prepare.

AUDIENCE SEGMENT

Directly Affected Employees

WHAT THEY CARE ABOUT	WHAT TO INCLUDE	CHANNEL	TIMING
What this means for my role, my team, my daily work, my future.	What is changing and what is not. Timeline. Support available. Where to go with questions. Next steps.	Team meeting or all-hands with live Q&A. Written follow-up. Individual conversations for high-impact cases.	After managers are briefed and prepared. Simultaneously across all affected teams.

AUDIENCE SEGMENT

Indirectly Affected Employees

WHAT THEY CARE ABOUT	WHAT TO INCLUDE	CHANNEL	TIMING
Is my role at risk? What does this mean for the organisation?	High-level summary. What is and is not changing for them. Who to contact with questions.	All-staff communication. Email or intranet. No need for live session unless scale warrants it.	Same day as direct communication or within 24 hours. Rumour fills any gap.

AUDIENCE SEGMENT External Stakeholders			
WHAT THEY CARE ABOUT Continuity of service. Contractual obligations. Public reputation.	WHAT TO INCLUDE What changes for them. Timeline. Their point of contact. What they need to do (if anything).	CHANNEL Personalised communication from the relevant relationship owner. Formal letter if contractual.	TIMING Coordinated with internal communication. Not before employees are informed.

Channel Selection Matrix

Choose your channel based on the nature of the message — not on what is most convenient for you as the sender. The right channel signals the right level of importance. An email for a redundancy says, without words, that this person does not deserve your time.

THE RULE OF SENSITIVITY

The more sensitive the message, the more personal the channel must be. Sensitive or emotional communications always require a live, synchronous conversation where the recipient can respond in real time. Written channels — however well crafted — do not allow the other person to ask a question, express a reaction, or receive acknowledgment in the moment. For anything that matters to a person's livelihood, identity, or wellbeing: show up in person.

Channel	Sensitive News	Emotional Topics	Strategy / Change	Routine Updates	Guidance
Face-to-face (1:1)	✓	✓	✓	✗	High emotional impact. Redundancies, performance, major personal news.
Face-to-face (group)	✓	✓	✓	✗	Team briefings, strategy announcements. Allow live Q&A.
Video call (1:1)	✓	✓	~	✗	When in-person is not possible. Use for sensitive topics only if face-to-face is unavailable.
Video call (all-hands)	✓	✓	~	✗	Large-scale change announcement. Must include live Q&A, not just broadcast.
Email	~	✗	✓	✓	Written record, confirmation of verbal communication, broad informational updates. Never for sensitive news.
Intranet / Sharepoint	✗	✗	✓	✓	Reference material, FAQs, supporting documentation. Always supplementary, never primary.
Instant message / Slack	✗	✗	~	✓	Informal updates, quick confirmations. Too informal for significant communications.
Video message (recorded)	~	✗	✓	✓	CEO or leader update where live session is not feasible. Supplement with written Q&A.
Town hall (in-person)	✓	~	✓	✗	Major change communications to large groups. Include live Q&A — broadcast-only town halls erode trust.
Written letter / memo	~	~	✓	✓	Formal or legal communications. Changes to terms and conditions, contractual matters.

✓ = Well suited ~ = Use with caution ✗ = Not recommended

ONE FINAL CHECK

Before you communicate, ask yourself: if I received this message, in this way, at this time — would I feel respected, informed, and clear about what happens next? If the answer is no, go back to the checklist.